White

Space · a clean sheet · a breath

White can be a freshly made bed, snow, a porcelain mug or a canvas you stand in front of with a brush and suddenly don't know whether you dare at all. Sometimes it offers you relief. At other times you feel that nothing may be touched here. What do you see in it? Purity, freedom, emptiness, a hospital, or a festive moment?

This page does not tell you what white means. **It shows it to you from several sides**. How it is mixed, how it is painted with, where its reputation comes from, how it is read in different cultures and **what it can awaken in us**.

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How to mix the colour and its shades

You will not get white paint by mixing red, yellow and blue. You need a white pigment, or you let white paper or ground show through. With light it is different. A suitable combination of coloured lights can produce a white impression. A palette and a spotlight simply do not share the same procedure.

Every white is a little different. **Titanium white** usually covers well and lightens mixtures strongly. More translucent whites behave differently and the kind of paint matters too.

What to prepare

White
For ordinary work with acrylic, titanium white can be the base.

Yellow or ochre
For warmer, creamy shades.

Brown
In tiny doses for broken whites.

Blue
For a cool tint.

Red or magenta
For a barely noticeable pink tinge.

Black
Really just a little, for off-white greys.

An unpainted spot is white too

With watercolour a white spot can arise by leaving the paper unpainted. With acrylic, on the other hand, you can apply white in a thick layer.

White therefore need not mean "there is nothing there". Sometimes it is the paper itself, at other times a proper layer of paint.

What the additions do

Yellow
Shifts toward cream. Add by the tip.
→

Ochre
Shifts toward ivory, softer and warmer.
→

Brown
Shifts toward broken white, gently earthy.
→

Blue
Shifts toward cool, bluish.
→

Red
Shifts toward pinkish white. Only a trace.
→

Black
Turns grey. The tip of a brush is enough.
→

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Ten whites to try

For these mixtures start with a larger heap of white and add only a trace of the other pigment. **Half and half is no longer a lightly tinted white**, but a completely different company. Take the ratios as a starting point for trying.

Pure white

White straight from the tube, a clean brush and a clean palette.

Cream

White and a tiny trace of yellow or ochre.

Ivory

White and a trace of ochre. According to the result even less brown.

Warm broken white

White and a tiny amount of warm brown.

Cool off-white

White and a barely noticeable trace of blue.

Pinkish white

White and a tiny amount of red or magenta.

Whitish grey

White and the tip of a brush of black.

Snow

Clean and slightly cool. Take care it doesn't turn blue.

Milk

Soft and smooth. Warmer than snow.

Bone

Natural and matte, close to linen.

Pearl and porcelain

A pearly look is created with pearlescent paint or medium. **White alone will not create glossy reflections.**

Names like milk, snow or porcelain are not exact recipes. Two manufacturers agree on ivory about as much as two families on the right potato salad. Compare samples side by side and in the same light.

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Rainbow – the chakra system

White has **no stripe of its own** in the rainbow. Sunlight, which we perceive as white, contains various wavelengths. Water drops separate them when a rainbow forms, so we see a colour spectrum. White light and white paint on a canvas are not the same thing, though. In some contemporary approaches it accompanies the **crown chakra** and the themes of wholeness and transcendence.

The whole rainbow as a map of questions

Red · root
Support, safety, presence. Ask yourself. What can I lean on?

Orange · sacral
Experiencing, pleasure, sensuality. Ask yourself. What does me good?

Yellow · solar plexus
Self-worth, will, decision-making. Ask yourself. What do I want to choose for myself?

Green · heart
Closeness, kindness, relationships. Ask yourself. Where can I be open and still stay with myself?

Blue · throat
Voice, expression, communication. Ask yourself. What do I need to say?

Indigo · third eye
Inner vision, intuition, discernment. Ask yourself. What is beginning to dawn on me?

Violet · crown
Transcendence, meaning, connection. Ask yourself. What gives me a wider sense of meaning?

White · beside the crown
Space and a breath. Ask yourself. Must I fill every free spot with something at once?

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The crown chakra and transcendence without obligation

Chakras come from the Indian yogic and tantric tradition. The seventh chakra is called Sahasrara and in classical texts violet or light is linked with it. White is added to it only in some contemporary spiritual approaches, beside violet, with the themes of wholeness and meaning.

White here is not a confirmation that someone has reached a higher stage of development. A white dress can be beautiful. A spiritual certificate is not included with it, though. The assignments also differ among traditions.

When white does you good. It brings you relief, quiet and fewer stimuli. You feel fresh in it and have room for your own decisions.

When white does not do you good. You feel that nothing must be spoiled, or it reminds you of a hospital or an unlived-in flat. These are not proofs of the state of a chakra. They are situations in which you can get to know yourself.

A space that is not emptiness

- **Put it beside**
  White paper next to a colour that attracts you. Perceive them for a while without looking for the right meaning.
- **Leave the sheet empty**
  Lay a white paper in front of you. You need not write an intention or come up with an answer at once. Notice what it is like to leave it empty for a while.
- **Put it on**
  A simple white T-shirt or shirt after a period full of changes. Fewer stimuli, less need to explain yourself.
- **Put it in a room**
  One light wall, shelf or lamp. A light wall does not behave like a white room.
- **Paint it**
  One thin layer of white on coloured paper. Notice your hand, the pressure and whether you want to continue.
- **Open the window**
  Daylight and fresh air do more for a space than the colour of the wall.

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When there is already too much white

The meaning of the search can turn into another obligation. You keep reading, looking for explanations and trying to work out what life "wants to tell you". Until there is no room left simply to live something. If emptiness unsettles you, you can add colour, touch a table or look around the room. **You do not need more white.** You need to invite tangible colours.

- **With brown**
  Do I feel support and my body?
- **With red**
  Is there room for strength and anger?
- **With green**
  Do I have closeness and breath?
- **With black**
  Do I see a clear contrast that helps me tell things apart?

This is inspiration from tradition, not treatment. It is not about measuring chakras. You notice how the relationship of colours affects you and what theme it reminds you of.

Picture it with an example

Next to white other colours can feel calmer. Red gets its surroundings, yellow softens, green recalls spring leaves on a light wall. **These are possibilities for personal reading**, not effects prescribed by a colour combination.

How to use this map

It is a way to sort out the themes you are living through. Do you add a colour because you miss liveliness, or do you not need it because calm is enough? **You choose the meaning.** Both options can be fine.

White has no eighth place in the classical seven-colour map.

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Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for white when we want **to take a breath**, or when we need **to correct or soften**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

Fear of the first stroke

An empty canvas looks perfect. Then you are supposed to come and do something on it. The first coloured mark does not exist yet and already carries the responsibility for the whole picture.

If a white surface binds you, start on a smaller paper, make a mark by the edge or lightly rub the canvas with a thin tint. **The point is not to overpower yourself.** The point is to find a beginning from which you can continue.

Smaller paper.

Ordinary paper that you need not show anyone.

A mark by the edge.

The first stroke off centre.

A thin layer.

The canvas lightly tinted so that it is not so white.

A long exhale.

Before you begin, just breathe and look for a while.

Music or silence.

Which helps you more to put judgement aside?

Two papers.

One for trying and one for real.

White in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. A white area is not automatically a message of emptiness or purity. It can mean calm, light, a pause, dissolved contrast or just that the paper stayed paper. A white picture can be full of happening.

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Leaving a white spot is not a mistake

Perhaps you feel a need to fill every part of the picture, because otherwise it looks unfinished. Try leaving one place free for a while.

Does it attract you? Disturb you? Do you feel the picture has gained space? Or do you really want to continue? You need not defend an unpainted spot. And you need not keep it just because it is called airiness.

Imagine the same empty spot in three pictures. In the first it is a breath, in the second a forgotten corner, in the third an invitation. **The colour has not changed. What you do with it has.**

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Covering is not the same as erasing

With white you can cover an older layer, soften it or let it partly show through. Sometimes covering is a relief. At other times you find you keep correcting something that a moment ago still seemed alive to you.

From a white repaint one cannot read that you reject the past. On a later look back, though, you may be curious what the covering was like for you.

Three things worth noticing

- **SHAPE**

An area, a line, or an overlay?

A white line on a dark ground can join. A large area can create space and emptiness. While working you need not decide what exactly it means. Only later can you ask whether the stroke meant relief for you, or just the pleasure of a clean surface.

- **WEIGHT**

Light, or lifeless?

If white feels pleasantly light to you, leave it alone for a while and watch its shape. If the area is too sharp, add a trace of ochre, brown or pink. If everything blends, add a difference of surface, direction of strokes or translucency.

- **COURAGE**

You need not finish at once

Courage in painting does not have to mean that you must intervene in everything at once. If you want to leave an area free, try a few strokes in another direction or a relief. If you keep covering earlier layers, notice the feeling of covering itself. The interpretation can wait.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a white stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning.** That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

- **I'm afraid of spoiling the canvas**
  Make a few marks on ordinary paper that you need not show anyone.
- **The picture feels overcrowded to me**
  Try a small light area or a translucent overlay.
- **White is too sharp**
  Add a trace of ochre, brown or pink.
- **I keep correcting everything**
  Put the brush down for a while and look from a greater distance.

Do you want to paint only with white? Try relief, layers, different directions of strokes and the difference between a matte and a glossy surface.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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Associations and stories

Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "white = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

From the body

White is the colour of **light, snow and milk**. A light surface reflects more light, lets shadows stand out and seems cleaner. That helps explain why white can relate to clarity as well as to the feeling that you must not spoil anything.

From culture

In Europe white is linked with **weddings, innocence and purity**, elsewhere with mourning. A coat, a duvet, porcelain, a gallery. At the same time it is the colour of healthcare and of empty new flats. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

From what you have lived

Bedding at grandma's, the first white shirt, a hospital corridor, a new flat without furniture. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same white** and one feels relief, the other pressure.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "white" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does white connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**

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Stories

White has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

White on white

In **1918** Kazimir Malevich painted the picture Suprematist Composition. White on White, oil on canvas measuring 79.5 by 79.5 centimetres. Today it is held by the Museum of Modern Art in New York. The picture shows a white square, slightly tilted and shifted off centre, on a somewhat warmer white field.

According to descriptions, the white was to evoke infinity and the tilt movement. White here is neither emptiness nor purity. It is **a surface on which a difference can hardly be glimpsed, and yet it is there**.

White marble statues

Greek and Roman statues were often painted, especially clothing and hair. The colour wore off over time, so antiquity became a white idea. According to an overview this influenced eighteenth-century classicism and its white façades too. Traces of colour were found, for example, on the Parthenon and on the statues from the temple of Aphaia on Aegina.

André Malraux wrote that "Athens was never white". White was not the intention of antiquity. It was **the result of time and of our way of looking**.

The white that killed

Lead white was made from lead and vinegar and was the main white of European painters until the nineteenth century. It was used for underpainting, highlights and flesh tones. It was poisonous, though. In the eighteenth century Europeans whitened their skin with lead, even though they knew the danger.

It was later replaced by zinc white and titanium white, which was first produced in large quantities in **1916**. White became safer, covers well and lasts. Today most paint manufacturers expressly discourage lead white. It shows that **purity and safety do not always go hand in hand**.

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Emotions and feelings

The same white can evoke **relief** in one of us and **pressure** in another, sometimes even both in one day. There is no single fixed effect. It depends on our body, experience, culture and situation.

Emotions

Quick and strong reactions that can appear even before you realise them.

Relief

A feeling that **there are fewer stimuli** and you can breathe out.

And why?

After a period full of changes, people and demands, simplicity may attract you. White bedding, a light wall, a desk without a pile of things. Perhaps you do not want a new life. You just don't want your room to remind you of ten unfinished tasks.

Ask yourself

"What would I like to put out of sight today?"

A new beginning

A feeling that it is **a clean sheet** and you can start in your own way.

And why?

A new notebook, an unpainted canvas, an empty shelf. Everything can still be different. At the same time it can press, because the first mark is no longer innocent.

And what if I asked you now?

"What would I begin if I did not need certainty?"

Celebration

A feeling that it is **an exceptional moment**.

And why?

A wedding dress, a christening, a suit for a garden party. White belongs to celebrations and attention. It can carry joy and also pressure for everything to look flawless.

And try answering now

"What am I looking forward to so much that I would wear something white for it?"

Emptiness

A feeling that **something is missing** here.

And why?

Perhaps you have a hospital stay behind you. Perhaps white reminds you of an unlived-in flat. Or you simply don't enjoy a surrounding where colours and personal things are missing.

And now one question for you

"What should belong here and is not here yet?"

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Feelings and experience

Deeper and slower states that settle in us. You often recognise them only after a while.

Purity, or control

A feeling that you must **keep watching yourself** so that nothing shows.

And why?

Imagine a white sofa. In one home it is the place where you sit down with tea. In another you approach it under supervision. If a white surrounding makes you watch every crumb, perhaps it is not bringing you the calm you promised yourself from it.

Ask yourself

"Where at home am I afraid to leave a trace, and why?"

Calm

A feeling that there is **quiet and light** and you need not explain anything.

And why?

A snowy landscape, a new duvet, morning light. White can accompany moments when you truly rest. Colour is part of the experience, not a substitute for rest.

And what if I asked you now?

"When did I last have nothing I had to do?"

Fear of a mistake

A feeling that **anything you spoil** will show.

And why?

On white every print, stain and stroke shows. A home should not be a place where you are afraid to leave evidence that you live in it. The colour itself demands nothing. The demand comes from what has stuck to it.

And try answering now

"Whose voice in me says that nothing must be spoiled?"

Freshness

A feeling that it is **fresh and light**.

And why?

A white shirt in summer, a blossom, foam on water, birch bark or clouds. White here is not sterile and has no need to be lifeless.

And now one question for you

"Where did I last see a white that was alive?"

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My white is not the same as your white

The colour itself **experiences nothing**. We experience it. When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), the **experience** sticks to it. The colour then becomes a **shortcut**. That is why **your own reaction** is the most important.

- **White dress** — For one a wedding, for another a farewell.
- **White coat** — For one care, for another a surgery she wants to leave.
- **White room** — For one light, for another an empty flat.
- **White duvet** — For one home, for another a hotel.
- **White paper** — For one an invitation, for another an exam.

Does it really make you look bigger?

Light clothing can under certain conditions look more voluminous than dark. The perceived size, though, is also affected by the cut, material, folds, shine, background and lighting. A white shirt alone does not add kilograms to the body. It changes its visual look. A loose black tunic need not look narrower than a well-fitting white dress.

"I don't have the figure for white"

Try to notice who is saying that sentence. You, looking at a specific garment? Or do you hear in your head someone's old remark again? You may want to emphasise a certain part of the body and leave another less conspicuous. That is your choice. But you need not put white aside entirely because supposedly one may wear it only after losing weight.

How to try white without talking yourself into it

Compare snow, cream and broken white near the face in the same light. Then try the garment in motion. Sit, walk around, raise your arms. That the fabric pulls across your hips is not white's opinion of your body. It is information about the cut. **White can be your choice. It does not have to be your obligation.**

Ask yourself

"Which sentence about white is loudest in me? Whose is it, actually?"

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White in cultures and traditions

White is a colour people long thought of as "obvious". Purity, a wedding, innocence. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about fashion, commerce and faith than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how white is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

White in different cultures

England

Queen Victoria married on 10 February **1840** in a white satin dress with Honiton lace. She is often cited as the one who introduced the white wedding dress, but that is not accurate. White had been worn earlier and Victoria's wide press coverage rather popularised it.

From a time when fashion became a custom and the custom "always".

White here is **a tradition with its own biography**.

Greece

Ancient statues and buildings were often painted. The colour wore off over time and what remained of antiquity was a white idea that classicism took over. Traces of colour were found, for example, on the Parthenon and on Aegina.

From a place that gave us a white ideal, and perhaps never had it itself.

White can be **a later beauty that we added ourselves**.

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Rome

The toga candida was a toga cleaned with chalk to a dazzling white. It was worn by candidates for public office. The Latin word candida means pure white and gave rise to the word candidate.

The Roman poet Persius is said to have spoken of it mockingly as "chalk-whitened ambition". White has thus long carried a suspicion of showing off as well.

White here is **an invitation for a person to show themselves**.

China

In some Chinese and other East Asian traditions white has a place in mourning ceremonies. Specific customs differ by place, family and religion.

A colour that may remind you of the beginning of a marriage thus accompanies farewell elsewhere.

White here is **a reminder that we read colours in the language of the environment** in which we grew up.

White in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at white **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the traditional five-element system white is linked with metal, autumn, the lungs, the large intestine and grief. For work with colour we can draw near the theme of receiving and letting go. Inhaling and exhaling alternate. An autumn tree also does not keep all its leaves just because it put so much work into them in spring.

How it relates to white. With people it is usually more complicated. We hold on to things, roles and obligations because "it has always been so". You can free up one shelf, put down an unrequested duty or notice that you keep a certain thing mainly out of guilt or habit. A white or light ground helps because on it you see better what you have kept. **White will not cleanse anything for you.**

And what if I asked you now?

"What do I want to keep and what do I no longer need to have constantly in front of my eyes?"

When something has ended

After a break-up, a loss or the end of a long period you may long for a lighter room. Not because you want to deny your previous life. Perhaps you need every object not to remind you of it. Or on the contrary you do not want to change anything. That too may be important at the time.

Autumn is not the end

A white fabric, a new cover or an empty spot on the wall can accompany a change. **You do not have to choose one position forever.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of “energy”, the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to white. In some yogic and Ayurvedically inspired interpretations white is used as an image of purity, clarity and calm. What is interesting for us is what you imagine under purity. Fewer disturbing stimuli? Honesty? Or the pressure of having no "bad" emotions?

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. Matte white and soft materials can feel cooling. A dazzling glossy white and sharp contrast may, on the contrary, irritate.

- **Matt and soft**
  Calming, as a base.
- **Beware of glare**
  Gloss can be one more stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. A cold white can feel empty. Cream and wool add warmth. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Cream and wool**
  Soft and warmer than pure white.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Warm light and soft textiles.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Light surfaces can lighten a space, but let them not be cold. **Add movement and colour to them.**

- **A light base**
  Lightens a heavy environment.
- **Add colour**
  Green or yellow as an accent.

We will therefore not make white a universal ban or a remedy for a particular dosha. More interesting is whether a specific form brings you comfort, or weighs on you.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe white as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement. In alchemy, after the nigredo comes the albedo, the whitening. In his works on alchemy Jung interpreted it as an image of purification and new light after the dark phase.

How it relates to white. In symbolic language you can read white as **the colour of possibility and of space before a decision**. When you think about it, ask what in it is yours and what belongs to the expectations of others.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same white can be relief for one woman and pressure for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui interpretations white is commonly linked with metal and can accompany the theme of clarity, simplicity and discernment. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

White is like paper

A little gives a space light, a whole room turns it into an examination room. The question is whether the arrangement helps you live, or whether you are trying to live so as not to spoil it.

Simple tips

- **Add texture**
  Wood, knitwear and linen can change the impression even without striking colours. The gain is the variety and personality of the space.
- **Change the lighting**
  Warmer evening light and more diffuse lamps do more than another colour.
- **Watch the surface**
  Matte white feels different from glossy. Gloss shows fingerprints and dazzles.
- **Leave something of your own**
  A picture, a book, a plant or a thing that is truly yours.
- **Compare shades in the room**
  A cold white next to cream looks bluish and cream in turn looks yellowish.
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a wall, try a throw or a larger sample.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH White is always clean and calm.

TRUTH Pure white under cold light can feel like a waiting room. A warm white with a creamy tinge is more homely.

MYTH White walls will make a room bigger.

TRUTH Light walls reflect more light, so the room feels airier. They cannot make it bigger, though, and white without textures can be empty.

MYTH White does not suit children and animals.

TRUTH It does, if you choose a washable paint and add a few darker elements. The whole room need not be like a gallery.

What white goes well with

- **Wood and brown**
  A more bodily, warmer impression. It prevents the room from looking like an examination room.
- **Green**
  Plants in front of a light wall look alive.
- **Black**
  A clear contrast that helps tell things apart. Watch the amount.
- **Pink**
  Softness or freshness depending on the shade.
- **Gold**
  A festive detail. Too much shine can look ostentatious.
- **Blue**
  Fresh and calm. Without warmth it can be cold.

Elements

- **Metal**
  White is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Water**
  Black and dark blue deepen it.
- **Earth**
  Brown and yellow warm it.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.

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Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. White walls can let a picture, books and plants stand out.

What to watch for. If the sofa, floor, curtains and furniture are white too, the room can feel like a flat before the keys are handed over.

A simple tip. Add different surfaces and a few things that are truly yours.

Kitchen

What works. White cupboards can create a light base.

What to watch for. On some surfaces you will see every fingerprint and begin to feel that something is always unfinished.

A simple tip. Notice the material and maintenance. A matte or textured surface behaves differently from a glossy one.

Bedroom

What works. White bedding can recall purity and rest.

What to watch for. Cold sharp light, glossy surfaces and bare walls, however, can shift the room toward an examination room.

A simple tip. Try warmer evening lighting, a cream throw or a wooden headboard. You need not abolish white.

Children's room

What works. A white wall can be the beginning of a story.

What to watch for. It should not be a ban on its continuation.

A simple tip. Leave room for pictures and the child's choice.

Study

What works. In a study white can be a clear ground.

What to watch for. If a desk or screen dazzles you against a dark surrounding, it tends to be tiring.

A simple tip. Adjust the light and contrast. White should not replace a well-prepared workplace.

Bathroom

What works. White can help give a lighter impression.

What to watch for. When strong light reflects from glossy tiles into your eyes, it can be unpleasant.

A simple tip. More diffuse lighting and more matte surfaces will help.

And try answering now

"What does white at home allow me and what does it forbid me?"

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Colour frequency and phototherapy

With white people talk about "white light" and a "higher frequency". It sounds as if it had its own number that could be read off. A white wall does not **produce** light, it only **reflects** part of the incoming light. Let us say what of this is **atmosphere** and what is already **treatment**.

And it is just here that it is good to leave aside **miraculous promises**. A white wall or a white lamp is not in itself a therapeutic light method.

There is no single white "photon number"

A white impression arises from a combination of light components. Different sources can look white, yet their spectral composition differs. A warm-white and a cool-white lamp can also create a different impression. Besides the shade, the intensity, the direction of the light and the time of day matter.

What bright light treatment is for

Bright light treatment is used, for example, for winter seasonal depression. Here it is no longer about a symbol of purity, but about the effect of light on systems linked with the daily rhythm and mood. Designated devices and a specific procedure are used. A room painted white is no substitute for them.

If you are considering this therapy because of marked seasonal difficulties, discuss suitability with a doctor. Your health, certain medicines and possible eye disease also matter.

What of this belongs in an ordinary day

Notice how much daylight you actually get. If you spend the day in dimness and sit in the evening under very bright lighting, **choosing a white colour for the room alone will not solve it**.

When it is pleasant to switch off

Dimness can help create a restful atmosphere. For some more darkness is pleasant, others need a guide light. You don't need to learn to love light for your work with colours to be right.

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Astrotype and colours

Are you Libra, Sagittarius or Pisces? The astrotype is a much broader topic than just the sun sign. If you really want to go into **depth**, knowing only your date of birth is not enough. The exact place and time of birth are also important, because only from them are the ascendant, the position of the Moon, planets and other parts of the horoscope calculated. Here, though, we stay only at the edge of what relates to colours.

Astrology does not assign white unambiguously. It is most often linked with the Moon (cycles and reflected light), sometimes with the Sun (clarity) or with Venus (purity and beauty). Sources differ here, so take it as inspiration. Depending on how the planet of your sign relates to white, it may feel close to you, or distant. Find your sign (the dates are approximate and change by year) and read what white may say to you.

The ascendant is the sign that was rising on the eastern horizon at the moment of your birth. According to astrological tradition it shows how you come across outwardly and how you enter the world, while the Sun sign describes more who you are inside. For each sign you will therefore find not only its character but also a short note on how the colour fits when it is your ascendant.

Aries (21 March – 19 April)

Your white

white · red · ivory

A white that **gives you room to take a breath before the start**.

Aries is linked with Mars, fire and the start of spring. White is for it a clean starting line, **the space before the first step**. White with red may suit you more than pastel.

What Aries is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality cardinal · ruler Mars

Aries opens the zodiac and you can tell that it is first. It is a **pioneer** who gets into things before thinking them through perfectly. It is direct, impatient and likes to compete. It gets angry quickly but forgives quickly too.

Its strength is the **courage** to begin. Weaker is perseverance in long, slow matters. It does best where something is happening and where it can act at once.

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What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want to start in your own way and without prejudice. It fits a new project, a new chapter and a cleared desk.

With Aries the strength is often in the first step. White can add **calm before it sets off**.

Shadow beginning without finishing

In the shadow, Aries keeps starting from the beginning, because an unfinished picture cannot be judged. White becomes an excuse.

Aries fears that if it finished something, it might lose. So it keeps opening new sheets.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **finish one small thing and leave it lying**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mars red or brown.

red · brown · ivory

Red and brown give white body and support.

Aries as ascendant

When Aries is your ascendant, you come across as direct, lively and decisive. People may see you as someone who gets straight to the point, and the first impression tends to be brisk.

White gives you a clean and open impression. Ivory and cream are the closest.

In everyday life

Take a white paper and draw one line on it. Just one.

*When you feel like setting out, take **a white scarf and five minutes at a window**. You do not have to prove anything.*

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Taurus (20 April – 20 May)

Your white

milky · brown · green

White as **linen, milk and a freshly made bed**.

Taurus is an earth sign linked with Venus, the senses and stability. White suits it in natural materials. Linen, cotton and porcelain as **luxury without shouting**.

What Taurus is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality fixed · ruler Venus

Taurus is an earthy, **patient** and sensual sign. It likes good food, pleasant materials, nature and security. It gets going slowly, but once it decides on something, it persists.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to enjoy the present moment. The weaker side tends to be stubbornness and finding it hard to let go of what is familiar.

What it can support in you

White can support the joy of touch and good quality. It fits where you want comfort and calm at once.

With Taurus it is often not only about colour but about surface. Matte white cotton and a glossy synthetic feel completely different.

Shadow comfort that fears a stain

In the shadow, Taurus fears to stain its calm. White becomes a display case you must not enter.

Taurus likes certainty and white promises it. Only then nobody knows when one may sit.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **sit down on the white sofa with tea** and let it be.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add green and cream.

green · cream · ochre

Green and cream give white freshness and warmth.

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Taurus as ascendant

When Taurus is your ascendant, you come across as calm, stable and pleasant. You build trust slowly and people often feel firm ground in you.

White gives you a calm and trustworthy impression. Milk and cream suit more than snow.

In everyday life

Take a white mug in your hand and notice how it sits in your palm.

White bedding and a good book. ***Treat yourself to them without apology.***

Gemini (21 May – 20 June)

Your white

snow · yellow · sky blue

A white that **frees up room for new ideas**.

Gemini is an air sign linked with Mercury, curiosity and speech. White suits it as clean paper to write on. A white notebook, **a whiteboard and a light day**.

What Gemini is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Gemini is **curious**, talkative and adaptable. It learns quickly, likes to tell stories and enjoys it when a lot is going on around it. It can see several sides of one thing.

Its strength is **lightness** and wit. The weaker side tends to be scatteredness and a tendency to start more things than can be finished.

What it can support in you

White can support moments when you look for room for ideas. It fits a diary, a work desk and a bag.

With Gemini the strength is often in ideas and words. White can add **focus and silence between sentences**.

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Shadow endless drafts

In the shadow, Gemini writes drafts that never go out. A white page is an invitation and an excuse at once.

Gemini likes to experiment and white allows it to rewrite everything. Only then nothing ever leaves.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **send one sentence before it is perfect**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury yellow or light blue.

yellow · sky blue · white

Yellow and blue add clarity of thought and airiness.

Gemini as ascendant

When Gemini is your ascendant, you come across as lively, friendly and chatty. People may see you as curious and youthful, even if inside you are perhaps calmer.

White gives you a lighter and cleaner impression. Snow and sky are the lightest.

In everyday life

Take a white notebook and write down in it three things that interested you today.

*When it seems you are playing a role, give yourself **a moment of silence with white paper**. You do not have to joke about everything.*

Cancer (21 June – 22 July)

Your white

white · silver · milky

White as **moonlight on a duvet**.

Cancer is a water sign linked with the Moon, home and feeling. White may seem to it like a soft light in which one can rest. Milk and silver may remind you of **a full moon outside the window**.

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What Cancer is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality cardinal · ruler Moon

Cancer is **caring**, sensitive and strongly connected to home and family. It has a good memory for feelings and relationships. It enters the world cautiously, much like a crab with its shell.

Its strength is **empathy** and the ability to create safety. The weaker side tends to be changeable moods and a tendency to withdraw when it feels hurt.

What it can support in you

White can support moments when you need to calm down. It fits a bedroom, a house and clothing.

With Cancer the strength is often in empathy. White can add **permission to let yourself be looked after**.

Shadow care as an admission ticket

In the shadow, Cancer cares so that someone will need it. White becomes the uniform of helping.

Cancers fear rejection and white gives them a feeling of being "all right". Then nobody sees that they need something too.

The colour can help you here too. It can help you **say one thing that you need** and leave it at that.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Moon silver and cream.

silver · cream · rose white

Silver and cream give white light and openness.

Cancer as ascendant

When Cancer is your ascendant, you come across as gentle and careful. At first you keep your distance, but then warmth unfolds and people see in you someone who will look after them.

White gives you a sense of calm and care. Milky and soft shades suit.

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In everyday life

In the evening take a white mug in your hand and sit for a while without tasks.

*When you are tired of watching over everything, put on **a white shirt** and remind yourself that rest belongs to you too.*

Leo (23 July – 22 August)

Your white

white · gold · red

A white that **lets you shine without noise**.

Leo is a fire sign ruled by the Sun. White suits it as a stage on which gold and red stand out. A white jacket, gold jewellery and **a striking lipstick**.

What Leo is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality fixed · ruler Sun

Leo is **generous**, proud and creative. It likes to give, likes to rejoice and needs others to see and appreciate it. It is loyal and has a big heart.

Its strength is **warmth** and the ability to inspire others. The weaker side tends to be sensitivity to criticism and a tendency to want to be the centre of attention.

What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want to be seen and at the same time keep calm. It fits a celebration, a performance and summer.

With Leo the strength is often in creativity and generosity. White can add **calm dignity**.

Shadow perfection as a stage

In the shadow, Leo performs flawlessness so that nobody can reject it. White becomes a costume of purity.

Leo needs recognition and white gives it an impression of shine. When the glances vanish, tiredness arrives.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **choose a white that pleases you**, even if nobody will judge it.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add gold or deep blue.

gold · dark blue · red

Gold and dark blue give white shine and maturity.

Leo as ascendant

When Leo is your ascendant, you come across as self-assured, warm and striking. You enter a room in a way that people notice you even when you do not want them to.

White gives you dignity. Snow and ivory suit better than greyish.

In everyday life

Put on something white today with one radiant thing.

*When you feel you must shine, take **a white coat and coloured jewellery**.*

Virgo (23 August – 22 September)

Your white

white · whitish grey · green

White as **a clean desk and the silence after tidying**.

Virgo is an earth sign linked with Mercury, order and care for detail. White suits it in clean and precise forms. **A whiteboard, clean paper and a shirt** without needless ornament.

What Virgo is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Virgo is **meticulous**, attentive and practical. It notices details that others overlook and likes to be useful. It tends to be modest and judges itself more strictly than others.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to improve things. The weaker side tends to be perfectionism, worries and a tendency to criticise itself.

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What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want to tidy up both space and head. It fits a work desk, a wardrobe and a pantry.

With Virgo the strength is often in attention and order. White can add **a little forgiveness**.

Shadow control that knows no calm

In the shadow, Virgo guards every trace so that white stays white. The house turns into a display case.

Virgo is strict with herself and white makes that easy. Only rest never arrives.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **leave one fingerprint on the glass** and do nothing about it.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury grey and green.

whitish grey · green · cream

Grey and green add order and calm.

Virgo as ascendant

When Virgo is your ascendant, you come across as neat, restrained and reliable. People see you as observant and sensible, sometimes even overly reserved.

White gives you a gentle and careful impression. Cream suits better than a harsh white.

In everyday life

Put a white pen or mug on your desk and do not correct anything about it.

*When you feel strict, try **leaving one thing imperfect** and looking at it in warm light.*

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Libra (23 September – 22 October)

Your white

white · powder pink · silver

A white that **suits you in gentleness and balance**.

Libra is an air sign ruled by Venus. White suits it in elegant and balanced forms. Powder and silver as **a white dress with delicate jewellery**.

What Libra is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality cardinal · ruler Venus

Libra longs for **harmony**, beauty and justice. It is diplomatic, sociable and has a feel for aesthetics. It lives best in relationships in which it does not feel alone.

Its strength is **tact** and the ability to see both sides. The weaker side tends to be hesitation and a tendency to avoid conflict even when it would help.

What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want beauty and balance without shouting. It fits a flat, clothing and work.

With Libra the strength is often in taste and diplomacy. White can add **permission to stay with your own**.

Shadow balance that says nothing

In the shadow, Libra keeps everything neutral so as not to hurt anyone. White becomes a silence that contains nothing.

Libra wants everything to match. So she postpones her own opinion, because it could spoil the appearance.

The colour can help you here too. It can help you **write one sentence that you truly think** and let it hang.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Venus green and powder pink.

green · powder pink · white

Green and powder pink add calm and reality.

Libra as ascendant

When Libra is your ascendant, you come across as elegant, pleasant and balanced. People like you for your tact, even if inside you take a long time to decide.

White gives you a pleasant and balanced impression. Milk suits your manner best.

In everyday life

Try a white scarf or a porcelain bowl on the table and notice what you like and what merely does not bother you.

*When everything feels too perfect to you, give yourself **one thing in a softer shade** that has a voice of its own.*

Scorpio (23 October – 21 November)

Your white

white · wine · black

A white that **allows depth without drama**.

Scorpio is a water sign linked with Mars and Pluto, depth and transformation. White is for it a clean sheet after a storm, **in which something can be left to settle**. Wine and black may be closer to you than pastel.

What Scorpio is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality fixed · ruler Mars, in the newer view also Pluto

Scorpio is **intense**, deep and loyal. It feels strongly, but does not always show it. It dislikes superficiality and likes to get to what is hidden.

Its strength is **determination** and the ability to transform. The weaker side tends to be distrust, jealousy and a need to keep things under control.

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What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want to be close, but in your own way. It suits a private detail.

With Scorpio the strength is often in depth and loyalty. White can add **calm after the storm**.

Shadow a clean slate instead of forgiveness

In the shadow, Scorpio wipes out the past so as not to have to forgive. White becomes an eraser that leaves not even a keepsake.

After being hurt, Scorpios open up with difficulty. White means for them that nothing hurts any more, and at the same time nobody knows anything.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **keep one keepsake and look at it in the light**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add white with dark wine.

wine · red · black

Wine and red give white warmth and depth.

Scorpio as ascendant

When Scorpio is your ascendant, you come across as focused, mysterious and strong. People sense the intensity of your gaze and often feel that you know more than you say.

White gives you a calm depth behind a mysterious impression. Ivory is the closest.

In everyday life

Try having white just for yourself in something nobody sees.

*When you want to withdraw, put **a white thing under dark clothes** and let it be your secret.*

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Sagittarius (22 November – 21 December)

Your white

white · brown · gold

White as **snow on the road**.

Sagittarius is a fire sign linked with Jupiter, freedom and distances. White suits it as the colour of mountain peaks and an unwritten map. Brown and gold as **the road and warmth at the end of the day**.

What Sagittarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter

Sagittarius is **optimistic**, open and free-spirited. It loves travel, new experiences and the search for meaning. It speaks honestly, sometimes a little too directly.

Its strength is **enthusiasm** and faith in a good outcome. The weaker side tends to be impatience with detail and a tendency to promise more than can be managed.

What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want to set out but have somewhere to return to. It fits a journey, nature and a café.

With Sagittarius the strength is often in optimism and momentum. White can add **the awareness of where you set out from**.

Shadow endless roads without a destination

In the shadow, Sagittarius maps so as never to arrive. White is a map on which a destination is never marked.

Sagittarians love freedom and white allows them everything. Only then nobody knows where they are actually going.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **mark one place you will return to**.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Jupiter blue or gold.

blue · gold · green

Blue and gold give white reach and momentum.

Sagittarius as ascendant

When Sagittarius is your ascendant, you come across as open, jovial and adventurous. People see you as someone with a wide outlook and an appetite for discovery.

White gives you a friendly and open impression. Cream and brown suit more than harsh.

In everyday life

Take a white scarf or mug on the road and put it in the same place after you return.

*When something feels tight, try **looking to see whether it is only closeness**.*

Capricorn (22 December – 19 January)

Your white

white · slate · brown

A white that **lets you be firm and light at once**.

Capricorn is an earth sign linked with Saturn, responsibility and perseverance. White suits it in clean and sober forms, like **a white shirt and a clean desk**. Slate and brown add a maturity that can warm.

What Capricorn is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality cardinal · ruler Saturn

Capricorn is **responsible**, goal-oriented and disciplined. It likes to build and is not afraid of a long road. It has a dry sense of humour and shows it only to those it trusts.

Its strength is **perseverance** and the ability to see things through. The weaker side tends to be strictness with itself, reserve and a tendency to put joy off until later.

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What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want to lay a firm foundation without overloading yourself. It fits an office, a negotiation and long-term plans.

With Capricorn the strength is often in order and perseverance. White can add **a willingness to rest**.

Shadow seriousness without joy

In the shadow, Capricorn erases everything that makes no sense. White becomes an empty wall.

Capricorn fears that if it kept anything just for joy, it would achieve nothing. Then even pleasures are just another task.

The colour can help you here too. It can help you **find one place where nothing gets improved**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Saturn grey and cream.

slate · cream · brown

Grey and cream give white weight and warmth.

Capricorn as ascendant

When Capricorn is your ascendant, you come across as serious, mature and reserved. People may see you as older than you are, and only later discover how funny you are.

White gives you a trustworthy and calm impression. Ivory works best.

In everyday life

Put a white lining or button on serious clothing.

*When you are too strict, try to **look at a white thing and not improve anything**.*

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Aquarius (20 January – 18 February)

Your white

snow · sky blue · silver

White as **an unexpected idea** among colours.

Aquarius is an air sign linked with Saturn and Uranus, independence and ideas. White belongs to it as an inconspicuous choice that surprises. Snow next to silver looks like **the colour of a calm future**.

What Aquarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality fixed · ruler Saturn, in the newer view also Uranus

Aquarius is **independent**, original and idealistic. It is interested in ideas, humanity and the future. It wants to go its own way and does not like adapting to expectations.

Its strength is **perspective** and the ability to come up with new things. The weaker side tends to be distance from feelings and a tendency to withdraw when there is too much closeness.

What it can support in you

White can support moments when you want something unusual, but with calm. It fits a poster, a logo and clothing.

With Aquarius the strength is often in originality and perspective. White can add **firm ground under ideas**.

Shadow distance in a white coat

In the shadow, Aquarius observes everything from afar and experiences nothing. White becomes a laboratory coat.

Aquarians like to keep a detached view and white makes that easy for them. Only then the body waits for a touch that does not come.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take something rough and natural in your hand** and just notice it for a while.

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Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add a cool blue or silver.

sky blue · silver · white

Blue and silver give white clarity and distance.

Aquarius as ascendant

When Aquarius is your ascendant, you come across as independent, a little unusual and friendly. People see you as an original personality who keeps their own space.

White gives you an unexpected and friendly impression. Snow and silver are the closest.

In everyday life

For a week, try putting one white thing in your handbag and not explaining it.

*When everything seems too neutral to you, try **telling yourself what you like about it**.*

Pisces (19 February – 20 March)

Your white

milky · violet-grey · sky blue

White as **mist over water**.

Pisces is a water sign linked with Jupiter and Neptune, feeling and imagination. White can give it calm and lightness. Milky and sky tones may remind you of **foam on a sea wave**.

What Pisces is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter, in the newer view also Neptune

Pisces is **empathic**, intuitive and dreamy. It picks up the moods around it and often has a rich imagination. It frequently has a bond with art, music and spirituality.

Its strength is **compassion** and creative fantasy. The weaker side tends to be merging with other people's feelings, escaping into dreams and difficulty setting boundaries.

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What it can support in you

White can support moments when you need to anchor yourself. It fits a bedroom, a painting and a scent.

With Pisces the strength is often in empathy and imagination. White can add **a willingness to stand firm even in the current**.

Shadow dissolving in the mist

In the shadow, Pisces dissolves into white and cannot tell what is theirs and what is someone else's. Light turns into fog.

Pisces are sensitive and easily take on other people's atmosphere. White gives them comfort, but not direction.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **have one thing at home that you chose yourself**.

Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add white with blue or green.

blue · green · cream

Blue and green give white water and soil.

Pisces as ascendant

When Pisces is your ascendant, you come across as gentle, dreamy and adaptable. People like to project their wishes onto you and tend to be kind to you.

White gives you a soft and calm impression. Milky and sky tones are the closest.

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In everyday life

In the evening light a candle, take a white stone and write down three sentences about the day.

*When you feel like running away, take **a white thing firmly in your hand** and return to the room.*

FOR A DEEPER LOOK

Seasons

White is the colour of winter, snow and spring blossom. Summer wears it to celebrations and to the beach. Ask yourself when you reach for it.

Time of day

Morning and noon belong to white the most. In the evening it gains a warm tinge and under a lamp it changes shade. Compare shades under the same light.

Years of life

Saturn orbits the Sun roughly every 29 years. Astrology speaks of its returns at about 29 and 58 and reads them as times when a person asks what is truly theirs. In those years white may feel close to you as a clean sheet, or alien as pressure to start over. Both are natural. Research by Palmer and Schloss (2010) also reports that we like colours according to the things and experiences we link with them. Astrology does not rule that out; it just offers another view.

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Colour for your website and business

Yes, especially where you sell calm, clarity and a clean impression. White promises simplicity, but it can easily feel empty.

In business, white is a colour that **invites trust** but also carries the label of impersonality. It can look clean, light, modern and luxurious. So it is good to know what you promise before you let it into a logo, a website or an advert.

On its own, though, it does **not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help create **a clean impression**, but what mostly decides is **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

What we are telling the customer

White can say, for example

"It is clean." "It is simple." "It is modern." "There is room for you."

- **Cleanliness and care.** We often link white with a coat, clean linen and caring settings. But white is a visual signal, not a confirmation of hygiene or expertise.
- **Space.** Empty space helps separate information. If you remove even the important sentences, a visitor may admire the design and have no idea what you offer.
- **Celebration.** Weddings and ceremonies. Gold lettering on white looks festive, but it must stay legible.
- **Contrast.** A white background lets an image or product stand out.
- **Coldness.** Without a warm companion it can feel like an institution.

Depending on the shade, though, it also feels different. Cream and ivory are **warm and more playful**, snow is **fresh and cool**, pure white is **striking and graphic**.

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Simple tips

Add warmth
Wood, photographs of people or a gentle colour companion. Pure white on its own tends to be cold.

Show the product
A white product on a white background can be elegant, if people actually find it.

Shade by role
Pure white for graphics, cream for friendliness, snow for freshness.

Legibility
Light lettering on a light background vanishes. Watch size, contrast and text length.

A human face
Cleanliness need not stand in the doorway with arms crossed. Add plain language and a photograph.

Colour blindness
About 1 in 12 men has trouble telling red and green apart. Dark text on a light background is the safest choice for most people.

Professions where it is a Yes

The rule is simple. When you sell clarity, calm or a clean start, white can help you.

Healthcare and care

White can support an impression of cleanliness and expertise. Add personal touches so the place does not resemble an institution.

Galleries, photography and original work

A white background can let an image or product stand out. Empty space helps separate information.

Cosmetics, weddings and personal services

White can support freshness, festivity or simplicity. Wood, photographs of people or a gentle colour companion help if you want a friendlier impression.

Technology and design

A clean minimalist look is common there. Make sure the other elements show what you offer.

Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Very bright spaces.** A sum of white glossy surfaces can dazzle.
- **Settings for children.** A purely white design can feel too strict.
- **Care for people.** Without personal touches, white can resemble an institution.
- **Long texts on a website.** Grey lettering on white may vanish. Watch the contrast.
- **Product presentations.** Light products on a light background easily blend in.

The most important thing is not whether the design looks clean. It is whether a person understands where they have arrived and what to expect.

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Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask "What would you expect from such a place or service?" **Is the offer visible, or mostly the white?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that white means cleanliness.

A question for you

“What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?”

Examples from the market

You know white from soap, headphones and shelves. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Ivory (soap)**
  The soap was launched by Procter & Gamble in 1879. The white bar was whipped with air so it floated on water, and from 1895 the slogan "99 44/100% pure" was used. See. Here white carries a promise of purity.
- **Muji (household)**
  The brand began in 1980 as a line of the retail chain Seiyu. The name Mujirushi Ryōhin roughly means "good-quality goods without a brand". White and light materials with minimal advertising are part of its image.
- **Apple (headphones)**
  White headphones arrived with the first iPod on 23 October 2001. In adverts with a silhouette of a dancing figure, the white cable stood out against a bright background. White became a recognisable mark.
- **Dove (cosmetics)**
  The Dove Beauty Bar went on sale in 1957 in the United States. The Real Beauty campaign began in September 2004.

What they share is that white carries a simple message. **Clean, light, nothing superfluous.** And it mostly does not outshine what surrounds it.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.

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Different colour combinations

White + red

How it feels

Strength and a clean sheet. Red heats up white, and white gives red room. Together they feel bright and bold.

When it suits

When you want **expression and clarity**.

Specific shades

- white + red — *striking*
- ivory + wine — *clean*
- snow + coral — *bold*
- milk + scarlet — *festive*
- bone + brick — *muted*

In practice

A white shirt and red lipstick. A white wall and a red painting.

Watch out

Two strong colours tend to be loud. Add **wood or cream**.

White + orange

How it feels

Daybreak. Orange warms white and white calms orange. Together they feel fresh and playful.

When it suits

When you want **warmth without heaviness**.

Specific shades



- white + orange — *radiant*
- ivory + terracotta — *fresh*
- snow + apricot — *playful*
- milk + pumpkin — *bold*
- bone + rust — *earthy*

In practice

A white kitchen with an orange accent. A white shirt and an orange scarf.

Watch out

Too much orange next to white shouts. Try **softening it with something earthier**.

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White + yellow

How it feels

Sun on a wall. Yellow lights up white and white gives yellow calm. Together they feel joyful and clean.

When it suits

When you want **lightness and light**.

Specific shades



white + yellow
cheerful



ivory + ochre
golden



snow + butter
light



milk + lemon
radiant



bone + mustard
muted

In practice

A white wall and a yellow vase. White bedding and a yellow cushion.

Watch out

Yellow on white can be sharp. Keep it **as an accent**.

White + green

How it feels

Leaves on a light wall. Green stands out against a white background. Together they feel fresh and natural.

When it suits

When you want **a fresh and lively impression**.

Specific shades



white + green
natural



ivory + bottle green
woodland



snow + mint
fresh



milk + emerald
striking



bone + sage
quiet

In practice

A green plant in front of a white wall. White tiles and a green door.

Watch out

A sharp green next to white sounds loud. **Tone** the green down.

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White + blue

How it feels

Sky and clouds. Blue cools white and white brightens blue. Together they feel calm and fresh.

When it suits

When you want **calm and airiness**.

Specific shades



white + blue
calm



ivory + navy
airy



snow + sky
fresh



milk + cobalt
nautical



bone + denim
sober

In practice

A white shirt and blue jeans. White tiles and a blue door.

Watch out

Both tend to be cool. Without warmth the whole can seem **cold**.

White + indigo

How it feels

Porcelain. Indigo gives white depth and white gives indigo cleanness. Together they look like blue-and-white porcelain.

When it suits

When you want **depth without heaviness**.

Specific shades



white + indigo
dusky



ivory + ink
clean



snow + twilight blue
firm



milk + ultramarine
classic



bone + grey indigo
sober

In practice

A white sweater and indigo jeans. Blue-and-white porcelain in the kitchen.

Watch out

Dark and light side by side are sharp. Add **wood or linen**.

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White + violet

How it feels

Lavender. Violet gives white dreaminess and white gives violet room. Together they feel light and a little dreamy.

When it suits

When you want **delicacy and a sense of something beyond**.

Specific shades



white + violet
dreamy



ivory + plum
gentle



snow + lavender
mysterious



milk + orchid
rich



bone + grey violet
dusty

In practice

White bedding and a violet throw. A white dress and violet jewellery.

Watch out

Too much violet can feel cold. Add **a warmer shade**.

White + pink

How it feels

Gentleness. Pink softens white and white sets pink off. Together they feel fresh and tender.

When it suits

When you want **tenderness without sweetness**.

Specific shades



white + pink
tender



ivory + raspberry
gentle



snow + powder
fresh



milk + fuchsia
romantic



bone + dusty rose
discreet

In practice

A white shirt and a pink sweater. A white wall and a pink chalk.

Watch out

White and pink can feel bland. Add **a stronger companion**.

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White + grey

How it feels

Mist. Grey softens white and white brightens grey. Together they feel tasteful and restrained.

When it suits

When you want **elegance without shouting**.

Specific shades



white + grey
sober



ivory + graphite
elegant



snow + silver
light



milk + slate
modern



bone + dove
quiet

In practice

A white blazer and a grey sweater. A white wall and a grey carpet.

Watch out

Both are neutral. Without an accent it can be dull. Add **colour**.

White + brown

How it feels

Earth and light. Brown warms white and white brightens brown. Together they feel natural and cosy.

When it suits

When you want **warmth and support**.

Specific shades



white + brown
natural



ivory + chocolate
cosy



snow + beige
sober



milk + caramel
earthy



bone + linen
discreet

In practice

A white wall and a wooden table. A white shirt and brown shoes.

Watch out

Two neutral colours tend to be calm. Add **green or an accent**.

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White + black

How it feels

Chessboard. Black sets off white and white brightens black. Together they feel bright and graphic.

When it suits

When you want **clear contrast**.

Specific shades



white + black
clean



ivory + charcoal
elegant



snow + anthracite
graphic



milk + ink black
striking



bone + soot
sober

In practice

A black-and-white photograph. A white shirt and a black jacket.

Watch out

With small patterns the contrast can be distracting. Add **one calm area**.

White + gold

How it feels

Celebration. Gold sets off white and white gives gold calm. Together they feel festive and fresh.

When it suits

When you want **celebration without heaviness**.

Specific shades



white + gold
festive



ivory + old gold
rich



snow + champagne
gentle



milk + deep gold
radiant



bone + matte gold
muted

In practice

Gold jewellery on a white dress. White packaging with gold lettering.

Watch out

In excess gold drowns out calm and the space recalls **a shop window**.

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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **soften** white, add **cream**, **grey**, **wood** or **linen**.
- When you want to **bring it to life**, add **green**, **yellow** or **pink**.
- When you want to **deepen** it, **indigo**, **dark blue** or **brown** will help.
- When you want to **emphasise** it, add **black**, **gold** or **red**.

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